

Federal Court Dismisses McCain's PEF Patent Case Against Simplot

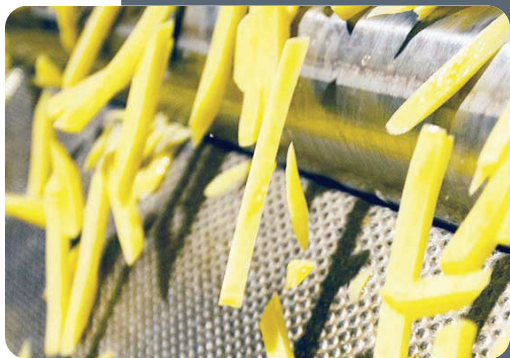
The Federal Court of Canada has ruled that Simplot's use of pulsed electric field (PEF) technology to pretreat potatoes does not infringe Canadian Patent No. 2,412,841 held by McCain Foods. The dispute hinged on the interpretation of "high electric field," with the Court siding with Simplot's narrower definition - 2 to 200 V/cm - excluding the much higher voltages

(over 1,000 V/cm) used in modern PEF systems. Justice McHaffie found McCain's claims invalid due to overbreadth and inutility, noting that McCain had not tested or predicted the effects at higher voltages. The Court also rejected McCain's objection to Simplot's expert witness, confirming the admissibility of common general knowledge testimony. It emphasized that Simplot's PEF system differed in



equipment, technical effects, and mechanism from McCain's patent. Simplot was awarded CAD 1.7 million in legal costs. The decision clarifies patent boundaries in non-thermal food processing innovation.

Clarebout to Build Frozen Fries Factory in Beijing by 2026



Belgian frozen fries producer Clarebout will build a new production facility in Beijing, targeting China's growing demand for frozen potato products. The plant is expected to be operational by the end of 2026. This follows Clarebout's recent joint venture with Dragon Fritopack in Zhucheng, where it acquired a 50% stake in an existing potato processing plant, securing a foothold in China's competitive market. The planned Beijing facility aims to support regional growth as urbanisation and Western-style foodservice trends drive consumption. In 2024, Clarebout reported €795 million in revenue - up 37% year-on-year - and €5.9 million in net profit. While investment details were not disclosed, the expansion aligns with similar moves by competitors like Aviko and McCain Foods, who are also increasing their presence in Asia. The new factory reflects Clarebout's long-term strategy to manufacture closer to key markets and respond to rising demand across the region, pending regulatory and construction milestones.



Intersnack to Invest €85 Million in German Plant Expansion

Intersnack will invest €85 million to expand its Alsbach facility in southwestern Germany, aiming to increase capacity, modernise production, and cut CO₂ emissions. The 10,000 m² extension will include a new production hall and logistics centre, enhancing operational efficiency. "Important prerequisites for this are sufficient capacities, state-of-the-art production technologies and qualified and committed employees," said Jan van den Broek, Managing Director of Intersnack Germany. Construction is set to begin in summer 2026, with the expansion supporting long-term employment for 470 workers. A major focus is sustainability, with plans to reduce the plant's carbon emissions by over 50% through a shift to renewable energy. The investment is part of a broader modernisation strategy across Intersnack's five German production sites. The company continues to grow through acquisitions, including KP Snacks' 2024 purchase of the Whole Earth brand. Demand for salty snacks, including potato-based products, remains strong.

Solynta Secures €20 Million EIB Funding to Advance True Potato Seed Technology

Solynta has secured €20 million in venture debt from the European Investment Bank (EIB), supported by the EU's InvestEU programme, to scale up its true potato seed (TPS) technology. The Dutch biotech firm is developing climate-resilient, disease-resistant potato varieties using TPS - small, storable, disease-free seeds that offer a sustainable alternative to traditional seed tubers. "Potatoes are a food staple around the world... making sure that they can grow in increasingly difficult climates and with higher chances of a good yield is extremely important," said EIB Vice-President Gelsomina Vigliotti. Solynta's non-GMO hybrid breeding platform accelerates development of blight-resistant varieties requiring fewer crop protection inputs. CEO Peter Poortinga noted the seeds' role in improving global food security. The investment aligns with the European Green Deal and the EU's Vision on Agriculture and Food, supporting resilient and competitive farming systems.

